

From Shannon Nicole, Switch to America

IS MY HOME TOXIC? THE CHEAT SHEET

Room by room. The everyday thing, what is actually in it, what it does to a body, and what to use instead.

How to use this. Find the row that matches something in your house. That is your starting point. You do not have to fix everything this week. Start with one thing.

Everything in here is public. None of it is a secret and none of it is hidden. Every chemical named on these pages has been studied, classified, recalled, banned somewhere, or sued over, and you can search any line of it yourself in about thirty seconds. That is the part that should make you angry. It was never hidden from you. It just was not printed on the bottle.

46 everyday things, across 6 rooms.

THE KITCHEN

You feed your family in here three times a day, and every single thing on this list touches that food.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Dish soap <i>Dawn Ultra, Palmolive Ultra</i>	Sodium laureth sulfate and fragrance, both printed right on the label of Dawn Ultra and Palmolive Ultra. The letters eth in the middle mean ethylene oxide gas was run through that ingredient to make it, and the reaction leaves 1,4-dioxane behind in the bottle. Nobody adds 1,4-dioxane on purpose, so it is a contaminant, and a contaminant legally never appears on any ingredient list.	Ethylene oxide, the gas that makes that ingredient, is a confirmed human carcinogen, IARC Group 1, and California lists it for cancer, birth defects and damage to both the male and the female reproductive systems. The 1,4-dioxane it leaves behind sits on California's Prop 65 cancer list, EPA grades it likely to be carcinogenic to humans, and the National Toxicology Program calls it reasonably anticipated to be a human carcinogen. It also damages the liver. New York had to pass a law capping 1,4-dioxane in household cleaning products at 1 part per million, which tells you how much was in there.	Our own dish soap. Then turn over every other bottle in the house and look for eth in the middle of a word.
Rinse aid, the bottle you refill in the dishwasher door <i>Finish Jet-Dry</i>	Finish Jet-Dry prints methylisothiazolinone and methylchloroisothiazolinone right on the label, side by side. They are preservatives for a water based product, and a rinse aid is built not to rinse off. That is the entire product. It leaves a film on the glass so water sheets away instead of beading, and that film is the last thing to touch the glass your family drinks out of.	Methylisothiazolinone is one of the most documented contact allergens in use. The American Contact Dermatitis Society named it Allergen of the Year, and Europe banned it outright from leave on cosmetics. America set no limit on it anywhere, not in cosmetics and not in the bottle you pour into your dishwasher door. Once your immune system learns to react to it, it reacts for life, so the rash comes back every time you touch it.	Our own dishwasher detergent, and stop using rinse aid completely.
The nonstick skillet, and the air fryer basket, waffle iron and rice cooker liner with the same coating <i>Teflon, made by DuPont and now Chemours</i>	PTFE, the nonstick coating itself, is a PFAS. It is built on the carbon fluorine bond, the strongest bond in chemistry, which is why nothing in your body and nothing in the ground breaks it down. Cookware carries no ingredient list, so the word PFAS appears nowhere on the box.	Run a nonstick pan empty on a hot burner and the coating starts breaking apart and giving off fumes. Those fumes kill pet birds in the same room, and in people the documented result is polymer fume fever, a flu that hits hours later. Scratch the surface and it sheds particles of that same PFAS straight into the food. The pan on the shelf today is made without PFOA, but the one in the back of your cabinet from before 2015 was made with it, and in 2023 IARC classified PFOA as carcinogenic to humans, Group 1.	Cast iron, stainless or glass. If a pan is scratched it goes in the trash today, not in the garage sale.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Plastic food storage containers, and anything plastic that goes in the microwave	Two different problems. BPA is in polycarbonate, the hard clear containers stamped 7, and in the epoxy that lines cans, and the BPA free version of that hard plastic swaps in BPS or BPF. The everyday tubs stamped 5 are polypropylene and carry no bisphenol at all, what they give up is the plastic itself. None of it is printed anywhere, because food containers carry no ingredient list and nothing in America requires anyone to tell you what is holding your leftovers.	BPA acts like estrogen in the body. California lists it as causing female reproductive harm, and the CDC found it in the urine of 93 percent of Americans tested. BPS and BPF come back estrogenic in the same testing, so BPA free does not mean hormone free. And when researchers microwaved plastic food containers, one square centimeter released millions of microplastic particles and billions of nanoplastic particles into the food in three minutes.	Glass containers with lids. Nothing plastic goes in the microwave again, microwave safe or not.
The plastic cutting board, the thin flexible mats and the thick white poly ones both	Polypropylene and polyethylene, coming off the board in pieces too small to see. There is nothing to read on it, because this is not an ingredient, it is the board itself shedding into your food while you chop.	You are eating the board along with the carrots. A polypropylene board puts about 79 million plastic particles a year into your food, close to 50 grams by weight, about ten credit cards worth, and particles that small cross out of the gut into the body, which is how plastic has been pulled out of human artery plaque and human brain tissue.	A wood board. That is the whole fix.
Your tap water, and the white pitcher filter you thought was handling it <i>Brita, the standard white pitcher filter</i>	Lead out of the service line, the solder and the brass fittings. Congress did not ban lead pipe and lead solder until 1986, so any home plumbed before that can have all three. Add PFOA and PFOS, and the trihalomethanes chloroform and bromodichloromethane, formed inside the pipe when chlorine meets the organic matter already in the water. Water comes with no label, so none of it appears anywhere, and the standard white pitcher filter is certified for chlorine taste and odor, not for lead and not for PFAS.	Lead takes a child's IQ, attention, growth and hearing, and EPA sets the safe level of lead in drinking water at zero. In an adult it damages the kidneys and raises blood pressure. IARC classifies PFOA as carcinogenic to humans, Group 1, and PFOS as possibly carcinogenic to humans. On the trihalomethanes, EPA writes the warning your utility has to mail you: people who drink water over the limit for years may have problems with their liver, kidneys or central nervous system, and an increased risk of getting cancer. That is the government's own wording about its own water.	A filter certified to remove lead and PFAS, and read the certification on the box before you buy it.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Bottled water, the case sitting in the garage	Nanoplastic and microplastic, mostly polyethylene terephthalate off the bottle itself and polyamide off the filters. It is a contaminant, so it is on no label. Neither is where the water came from, and purified on a label means filtered, not spring, which is why the biggest sellers print public water source on their own bottles.	When researchers put three top selling brands under a new laser method in 2024, they counted an average of 240,000 plastic particles in a single liter, ninety percent of them nanoplastics nobody had been able to see before. An earlier test of 259 bottles across 11 brands found plastic in 93 percent of them. Particles that size cross out of the gut. They have turned up in human placentas, including the baby's side, and in 2024 surgeons found plastic in the plaque they cut out of patients' arteries.	Filtered water at home, carried in glass or stainless.
The bottle of vegetable, canola or corn oil <i>Wesson, Mazola</i>	Refined seed oil, pressed and then washed out of the seed with hexane, a petroleum solvent. Hexane counts as a processing aid, so it never appears on the label. The refining also leaves trans fat in the bottle, and federal rules say anything under half a gram per serving shall be expressed as zero, so the front of the bottle prints zero.	Heat that oil to frying temperature and it throws off aldehydes, including formaldehyde. The World Health Organization's cancer agency calls formaldehyde a human carcinogen, Group 1, and the National Toxicology Program lists it as known to be a human carcinogen. Reuse the same oil, the way a restaurant does and the way most of us do at home, and the aldehydes build up in the pan and in the food. The word formaldehyde is not on that label and never will be.	Cook in beef tallow. Real fat in a cast iron pan, the way your grandmother did it.

THE LAUNDRY ROOM

You wash your family's clothes in here, and then they wear it on their skin all day and sleep in it all night.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Liquid laundry detergent <i>Tide, Gain, Persil, Dreft</i>	1,4-dioxane. It is created in the factory every single batch as a byproduct of how the cleaning agents are made, so it is a contaminant, not an ingredient, and it has never been printed on one bottle, in any state, ever. New York had to pass a law capping it in laundry detergent at 1 part per million.	Liver cancer, nasal cancer and gallbladder cancer in animals, plus liver damage and kidney damage from long term exposure. The federal government lists it as reasonably anticipated to cause cancer in people, and the EPA calls it a probable human carcinogen.	Every liquid jug comes off the shelf and our own brand goes on.
Dryer sheets <i>Bounce, Downy, Snuggle</i>	Acetaldehyde, sitting in the sheet itself and hidden under the one word fragrance, which no law makes them break open. Measured coming out of a home dryer vent during a normal load at more than 25 times the level in that city's outdoor air.	Nasal cancer and cancer of the voice box in animals that breathed it. Leukemia, lymphoma and bone cancer in animals that drank it, the federal government lists it as reasonably anticipated to cause cancer in people, and California put it on the state cancer list in 1988.	The box goes in the bin. Wool dryer balls do the same job.
Liquid fabric softener <i>Downy, Snuggle</i>	Quaternary ammonium compounds, called quats. They are not a contaminant here, they are the softener itself, the whole reason it works, and on the box they are called softening agents.	COPD, asthma, dermatitis and chemical burns on skin. In 73,262 American nurses, average age 54, the ones regularly using quats developed COPD at a rate a third higher, and COPD does not heal, lungs do not grow back.	Wool dryer balls and a half cup of white vinegar in the rinse.
Chlorine bleach <i>Clorox</i>	Sodium hypochlorite. This one is printed right on the front of the jug in plain sight, and it is still under half the laundry sinks in America.	COPD. In 73,262 American nurses, average age 54, the ones using bleach regularly developed COPD at a rate 36 percent higher, and mixed with the ammonia sitting in glass cleaner and floor cleaner it makes chloramine gas, which burns the lining of the lungs.	The jug leaves the house. Our own brand handles the whites.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Stain remover and whitening laundry booster	1,4-dioxane. Nobody puts it in on purpose, which is exactly why it is there. It shows up as a byproduct when the cleaning agents in stain sprays and boosters are made, and because it is a contaminant and not an ingredient, no federal law makes them print it. You will not find the word on a single tub or spray bottle in your laundry room. New York had to pass its own law capping how much of it is allowed in a bottle of household cleaner, and products got pulled off shelves over it.	The EPA classifies 1,4-dioxane as likely to be carcinogenic to humans. The National Toxicology Program calls it reasonably anticipated to be a human carcinogen, and California lists it under Proposition 65 as a chemical known to the state to cause cancer. It damages the liver and kidneys in animal testing. It does not break down, so it goes down your drain and turns up in drinking water.	No boosters, no stain sprays. Our own brand for stains.
The air blowing out of your dryer vent <i>Tide, Gain, Bounce, Downy</i>	Benzene, one of seven hazardous air pollutants measured coming out of a home dryer vent during a load of laundry. It is a contaminant, it is on no label anywhere, and it goes out the wall into the yard where your grandkids play.	Leukemia. Benzene causes acute myeloid leukemia in people, it is also tied to multiple myeloma and non Hodgkin lymphoma, it attacks the bone marrow where your body makes blood, and the EPA says there is no safe level of it.	The vent only puts out what you put in the machine. Change the detergent and the sheets to our own brand.
Anything in this room with a smell <i>Tide, Gain, Persil, Bounce, Downy, Snuggle, Dreft, scented OxiClean</i>	One word, fragrance, standing in for hundreds of separate chemicals. No federal law makes a laundry product name a single one of them, and when a researcher tested 37 scented products, fewer than 3 percent of what came off them showed up anywhere at all, not on the label, not on the safety sheet, not on the company website.	156 different chemicals came off those 37 products, and 42 of them are classified toxic or hazardous under federal law. In a national survey 34.7 percent of Americans reported a health problem from scented products, 18.6 percent respiratory problems, 15.7 percent migraines, 8 percent asthma attacks, and 12.5 percent got sick from laundry scent coming out of a dryer vent.	If it has a scent, it goes. Our own brand, and the laundry smells like nothing.
The fresh citrus scent in the detergent and the dryer sheets	Limonene, the citrus note, was the second highest chemical in the top selling detergent tested and the highest in the dryer sheet, and it reacts with the ozone already in household air and turns into formaldehyde. It is not on the bottle because it is not put in the bottle, it forms in the air of your laundry room.	Cancer. The World Health Organization's cancer agency classifies formaldehyde as a human carcinogen, it causes nasopharyngeal cancer, the cancer of the passage behind your nose, and it causes leukemia.	Kill the citrus. Our own brand, and open a window while you fold.

THE BATHROOM

You touch eight of these before you leave the house in the morning, and the worst thing in most of them is not printed anywhere on the bottle.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Shampoo and conditioner <i>TRESemme, Pantene Pro-V, Herbal Essences</i>	Sodium laureth sulfate, the ingredient that makes the lather, is made by a process that leaves 1,4-dioxane behind in the bottle. 1,4-dioxane is a contaminant, not an ingredient, so it is legal for it to be in there and no label has ever printed it. Then turn the bottle around and look for DMDM hydantoin. It is a formaldehyde releaser, it gives off formaldehyde the whole time the bottle sits open in your shower, and the word formaldehyde is never on that label either.	California has listed 1,4-dioxane as a chemical known to cause cancer since 1988. New York capped it at 1 part per million in personal care products, which tells you what companies were selling before somebody made them stop. Formaldehyde is Group 1 at the World Health Organization's cancer agency, carcinogenic to humans, for cancer of the nose and throat and for leukemia. You are standing in hot steam breathing it with your eyes closed.	Move shampoo and conditioner over to our own brand this month.
Dandruff shampoo <i>Head and Shoulders</i>	Pyrrithione zinc, 1 percent. It is the active drug ingredient and it is printed on the front of the bottle.	Europe classifies it as presumed toxic to human reproduction. On March 1, 2022 Europe banned it from every cosmetic sold there and every bottle came off the shelves, and it is still the active ingredient in the American one.	Take it out of the shower and wash with our own shampoo.
Body wash and liquid hand soap <i>Old Spice, Irish Spring, Dial, Dove</i>	The word fragrance. One word that legally stands in for dozens of chemicals the company never has to name, protected as a trade secret. Under it, the ingredients that start with PEG or end in cetareth or laureth are made by a process that leaves 1,4-dioxane in the bottle, and that one is a contaminant, not an ingredient, so it never appears on any label. Then the isothiazolinone preservatives, methylchloroisothiazolinone and methylisothiazolinone, which do get listed by name when they are used.	California has listed 1,4-dioxane as a chemical known to cause cancer since 1988, and New York capped it at 1 part per million in personal care products. Europe banned methylisothiazolinone outright from every leave-on cosmetic and capped it at 15 parts per million in rinse-off products, after enough women reacted to it that regulators moved. In the United States it is still legal in the soap your family uses every single day. And you cannot make an informed choice about a word that means dozens of chemicals nobody will name.	Every pump and bottle in this room goes over to our own brand.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Body spray, dry shampoo and anything that sprays out of an aerosol can <i>Old Spice and Secret aerosol sprays, pulled by Procter and Gamble in 2021 after benzene was found in them. Dove, Nexxus, Suave and TRESemme dry shampoos, pulled by Unilever in 2022 for the same thing.</i>	Benzene. It is not an ingredient anyone adds, it comes in with the propellant, which makes it a contaminant, and a contaminant legally never appears on the label. That is how it sat in name brand cans on shelves until an outside lab tested them and the recalls started.	The World Health Organization's cancer agency puts benzene in its highest category, carcinogenic to humans. It causes leukemia. California lists benzene as causing cancer and as causing developmental and male reproductive harm. No safe level of exposure has ever been set, and you are spraying it into the air you are standing in.	Nothing that comes out of an aerosol can. Switch to our own brand.
Body lotion and face cream <i>CeraVe Moisturizing Lotion</i>	Methylparaben and propylparaben, printed by name right on the CeraVe Moisturizing Lotion bottle. Cetareth-20 is on that same list, and ethoxylated ingredients like it leave 1,4-dioxane behind in the bottle as a manufacturing byproduct. That one is a contaminant, not an ingredient, so it never appears on the label at all.	Parabens are weakly estrogenic, which means your body reads them as a hormone. Europe cut the legal limit on propylparaben and made it illegal outright in any leave-on product for the diaper area of a child under three. Here it is legal in a lotion you rub into your whole body every night. California has listed 1,4-dioxane as a chemical known to cause cancer since 1988, and leave-on lotion is not rinsed off, it sits there.	Lotion is the easiest one to change. Move it to our own brand.
Antiperspirant <i>Secret, Old Spice, Sure, Degree, Speed Stick, Arm and Hammer, Suave</i>	Aluminum zirconium tetrachlorohydrate gly, or aluminum chlorohydrate. It is listed by name at the top of the Drug Facts panel on the back, as the active ingredient, because antiperspirant is legally a drug and not a cosmetic. Some of the aerosol versions also carried benzene out of the propellant, and benzene was never printed on the can because it was never an ingredient.	The aluminum plugs the sweat ducts in your underarm shut so the skin cannot sweat. The FDA requires every antiperspirant to carry a warning telling you to ask a doctor before using it if you have kidney disease. That warning is on the container in your bathroom right now and almost nobody has ever read it. In 2021 Procter and Gamble recalled aerosol Secret and Old Spice antiperspirant sprays after benzene was found in them, and benzene is Group 1, carcinogenic to humans.	Switch to our own deodorant and let your body sweat.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Toothpaste <i>Crest 3D White, Sensodyne</i>	PEG and polysorbate ingredients, made by a process that leaves 1,4-dioxane behind in the tube. New York's own environment department says flat out that you will not find it listed on the label, because it is a contaminant and not an ingredient. Crest 3D White lists Blue 1 and sodium lauryl sulfate by name, so those two you can read for yourself.	California has listed 1,4-dioxane as a chemical known to cause cancer since 1988. New York capped it at 1 part per million in personal care products. California banned Blue 1 outright from food served in its public schools. A dye the state will not let a cafeteria put on a child's lunch tray is in the paste you hand that same child twice a day, and a toothbrush goes in the mouth.	Move the whole family to our own toothpaste. Nothing you brush with should be blue.
Dental floss <i>Oral-B Glide, Crest Glide</i>	PTFE, the same chemistry as Teflon, coated onto the strand to make it glide. Floss is legally a medical device, which means it carries no ingredient list at all. There is nothing on that box to read, and that is by law.	PTFE is a PFAS, one of the forever chemicals. Researchers at the Silent Spring Institute tested women's blood and found that the women who flossed with Oral-B Glide carried more PFHxS, a PFAS, than the women who did not. PFAS stay in the body for years after a single exposure, and your body clears them slowly. The most studied chemical in that same family, PFOA, was classified carcinogenic to humans by the World Health Organization's cancer agency in 2023.	Get off the coated floss. Plain uncoated or silk floss, nothing that glides.

YOUR MAKEUP BAG

Nobody approved a single thing in this bag before it went on your face. The FDA does not clear makeup or the ingredients in it. The company decides its own product is safe and ships it.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Your eyeshadow palette, blush, bronzer and pressed powder <i>Claire's, Beauty Plus Global and City Color. The FDA's own 2019 testing found asbestos in talc cosmetics from all three, and the products came off the shelves.</i>	Talc. When it is in there it is printed on the label, and it is in most pressed powder, blush, bronzer and eyeshadow. Asbestos rides in with the talc as a contaminant, so it never appears on an ingredient list. There is still no federal rule in force requiring a company to test its talc for asbestos before it sells it to you.	Asbestos causes cancer. The World Health Organization's cancer agency puts every form of it in its highest category, carcinogenic to humans, and states there is no safe level of exposure. It causes mesothelioma and cancer of the lung, the larynx and the ovary. You are putting it on your face with a brush, near your eyes, every morning.	If the ingredients say talc, it goes in the trash. Switch to our own brand.
Loose setting powder and mineral foundation	Titanium dioxide, listed by name, sometimes written as CI 77891. It is what makes makeup opaque, so it is in nearly everything that covers, and loose powder and mineral foundation are close to pure pigment. This one is not hidden. It is printed right there.	California has required a cancer warning on titanium dioxide since 2011, for airborne unbound particles small enough to breathe. The World Health Organization's cancer agency classifies titanium dioxide as possibly carcinogenic to humans. Europe pulled it out of food in 2022 after its safety agency concluded it can no longer be considered safe to eat because damage to DNA could not be ruled out. Europe also wrote a separate cosmetics rule for the powdered form because of what people breathe, and caps how much can go into a loose face powder.	Put the loose powder down. Switch to our own brand.
Lipstick, gloss and lip liner <i>In the FDA's own test of 400 lip products, Maybelline Color Sensational in Pink Petal came back highest for lead at 7.19 parts per million, with L'Oreal Colour Riche right behind it. Lead turned up in all 400.</i>	Lead. It is a contaminant, which means by law it never appears on the label, and no lip product sold in America will tell you it is in there. The FDA found it in every one of the 400 lip products it tested, averaging 1.11 parts per million, with a high of 7.19.	Lead damages a child's developing brain. The CDC states there is no known safe blood lead level in children. California lists lead as causing cancer and as causing developmental and reproductive harm. It accumulates in the body over years, and lipstick is the one cosmetic you eat off your own mouth all day.	What goes on your lips goes in you. Switch to our own brand.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Waterproof mascara and long wear liquid lipstick	PFAS, the forever chemicals. Researchers screened 231 makeup products for fluorine and waterproof mascara was the worst category on the board, with 82 percent of the ones they screened coming back high. They then lab tested the 29 highest, every one of them contained PFAS, and exactly one of those 29 listed a fluorinated ingredient on the label.	PFAS do not break down, not in water, not in soil, not in you. The World Health Organization's cancer agency classifies PFOA, one of the family, as carcinogenic to humans, its highest category, on sufficient evidence in animals plus strong mechanistic evidence. California lists PFOA and PFOS as causing developmental harm. The EPA's legal limit for PFOA in drinking water is 4 parts per trillion.	Waterproof and transfer proof is the flag, and the label will not confirm it. Switch to our own mascara.
Mascara, liquid foundation, concealer and cream blush	DMDM hydantoin, quaternium-15, imidazolidinyl urea and diazolidinyl urea, all printed right on the label. In Europe the box has to say releases formaldehyde. In America it does not have to say anything.	They sit in the tube letting formaldehyde off slowly the whole time the product is on the shelf and on your face. Formaldehyde causes cancer of the nasopharynx and leukemia, and the World Health Organization puts it in its highest category.	Learn those four names and throw out anything carrying them. Switch to our own brand.
Lash glue and eyelash extensions	Formaldehyde. Researchers tested 20 professional lash glues, not one of the 20 listed it on the label, and 15 of them released it anyway.	Formaldehyde causes cancer of the nasopharynx and leukemia, and the World Health Organization calls it a human carcinogen. It is being released a quarter of an inch from your eye.	No glue, no extensions. Wear your own lashes and use mascara from our own brand.
Eyeliners, brow pencil and dark eyeshadow	BHA, butylated hydroxyanisole. It is the antioxidant that keeps the waxes, oils and pigments in pencils and pressed color from going rancid on your shelf. This one is printed right on the label as three letters, and nobody reads three letters as anything.	California has listed BHA as known to cause cancer since 1990. The National Toxicology Program calls it reasonably anticipated to be a human carcinogen. The World Health Organization's cancer agency classifies it as possibly carcinogenic to humans. It is still legal in American cosmetics, and still legal in American food.	Three letters. If a label says BHA, it goes. Switch to our own brand.
Body spray, dry shampoo and anything that sprays out of an aerosol can <i>Old Spice and Secret aerosol sprays, pulled by Procter and Gamble in 2021 after benzene was found in them. Dove, Nexxus, Suave and TRESemme dry shampoos, pulled by Unilever in 2022 for the same thing.</i>	Benzene. It is not an ingredient anyone adds, it comes in with the propellant, which makes it a contaminant, and a contaminant legally never appears on the label. That is how it sat in name brand cans on shelves until an outside lab tested them and the recalls started.	The World Health Organization's cancer agency puts benzene in its highest category, carcinogenic to humans. It causes leukemia. California lists benzene as causing cancer and as causing developmental and male reproductive harm. No safe level of exposure has ever been set, and you are spraying it into the air you are standing in.	Nothing that comes out of an aerosol can. Switch to our own brand.

THE AIR IN YOUR HOUSE

If a room in your house smells like vanilla or clean linen, that is not clean air, that is a chemical, and you are breathing it all day.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Scented candles, the jar kind you light at night <i>Yankee Candle, Bath and Body Works</i>	Formaldehyde, acetaldehyde, acrolein and benzo[a]pyrene, coming off the flame in the smoke. None of it is printed on the jar and it never will be, because a byproduct of burning is not an ingredient and no law makes anyone list it. You are not buying these four. You are making them in your bedroom every time you light the wick.	The National Toxicology Program lists formaldehyde as known to be a human carcinogen and names cancer of the nasopharynx and myeloid leukemia. Benzo[a]pyrene sits in Group 1 at the World Health Organization's cancer agency, the top group, carcinogenic to humans. The National Toxicology Program lists acetaldehyde as reasonably anticipated to be a human carcinogen. Acrolein burns the lining of the nose, the throat and the lung, and it is one of the reasons smoke hurts to breathe.	Blow it out. Open a window, or simmer orange peel and cinnamon on the stove.
Soy and unscented candles, the ones sold to you as the clean option	Ultrafine soot particles off the flame, small enough that they are counted in nanometers. They are not an ingredient, so they will never appear on a label, and no wax changes that. Soy, coconut, beeswax, unscented, the particles come from the burning.	A candle flame is one of the largest sources of ultrafine particles in a home. Particles that small get past your nose and throat and settle in the deepest part of the lung, past anything your body can cough back up. Nothing about soy wax removes the flame, so nothing about soy wax removes the particles. Clean was never the wax. Clean is not lighting it.	No wax burns clean. Open a window and run a fan, that is your air freshener.
Plug in scented oils <i>Glade PlugIns, Air Wick</i>	Di-n-butyl phthalate and diisobutyl phthalate, hiding inside the one word fragrance, so neither name is on the box. NRDC tested 14 air fresheners and found phthalates in 12 of them, including products sold as all natural and unscented, and not one label said so. Air Wick Scented Oil held four different phthalates in one bottle.	The European Union classifies di-n-butyl phthalate and diisobutyl phthalate as toxic to reproduction, its category for chemicals presumed to damage fertility and the unborn child. California lists di-n-butyl phthalate as a developmental and reproductive toxicant. A plug in runs warm in a closed room all day and all night, and you breathe it while you sleep. One word on the box legally covers the entire formula, so nothing there tells you any of it.	Pull every one out of the wall tonight and throw the refills away.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Citrus and pine plug in refills, the apple, pine and clean citrus scents <i>Glade, Air Wick</i>	Limonene and pinene, the chemicals that make the citrus and the pine. They are in the refill, and they do not stay limonene and pinene. Ozone comes into your house with outdoor air and gets made indoors by ionizers and ozone producing air purifiers, and when it meets those two they build formaldehyde and brand new ultrafine particles right there in the room.	Purdue measured that reaction running indoors. The National Toxicology Program lists formaldehyde as known to be a human carcinogen and names cancer of the nasopharynx and myeloid leukemia. What the reaction makes is formed in your living room, so it is not an ingredient and it will never be on the box. The more ozone in the house, the more you get, and running an ionizer feeds it.	Nothing that plugs in, nothing that sprays. Open the window and let real air do it.
Air freshener spray and fabric spray	One word, fragrance, legally standing in for hundreds of separate chemicals, and most air fresheners print no ingredient list at all. A University of Washington team tested 25 scented household products, found 133 different chemicals coming off them, and exactly one of the 133, ethanol, was printed on any label. The products were tested without brand names attached, which tells you the problem is the whole category and not one company.	Twenty four of those 133 chemicals are classified as toxic or hazardous under federal law. Four of them, acetaldehyde, 1,4-dioxane, formaldehyde and methylene chloride, are carcinogenic hazardous air pollutants under the Clean Air Act, a category with no established safe level of exposure. You spray them on the couch your grandchildren sit on and on the pillow you put your face in. Not one of the four has to appear on the can.	If it sprays a scent, it goes in the trash. Our own brand from here on.
Wax melts and the warmer they sit on <i>Scentsy</i>	Nanoparticles, and they are not in the box. The scent chemicals lift off the warm wax, meet the ozone already in your indoor air and build brand new particles between 1 and 100 nanometers wide right there in the room. Nothing formed in your living room counts as an ingredient, so the box gets to say flameless and women buy it believing no flame means no harm.	Purdue ran this in its full scale test house lab, a purpose built house wired with sensors that nobody lives in, and the flameless wax melts formed nanoparticles at rates on par with lit candles and gas stoves. Particles that small settle in the deepest part of the lung. The fragrance is the source, which means the warmer is only as clean as what you put in it. Flameless was never the same thing as emission free.	Unplug the warmer. The fragrance is the entire source, so nothing scented goes in it.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Solid air freshener blocks, toilet bowl deodorizer blocks and mothballs	Para-dichlorobenzene in some of them, naphthalene in the rest, and one of those two names is printed right on the box. This is the rare one you can catch in the store, and most women walk right past it because para-dichlorobenzene reads like nothing.	Para-dichlorobenzene caused kidney cancer, liver tumors and leukemia in animal testing. California put it on its cancer list in 1989 and it is still sitting there while the blocks stay on the shelf. Government scientists measured it in the blood of 953 American adults, and the ones carrying the most had about 4 percent less air coming out of their lungs. The National Toxicology Program lists naphthalene as reasonably anticipated to be a human carcinogen.	Toss the blocks and the mothballs. Cedar in the closet, our own cleaner in the bowl.

THE KIDS

Everything you rub on your baby goes in, because pound for pound she carries about three times the skin you do.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Baby powder <i>Johnson's Baby Powder, the talc version pulled from American shelves in 2020. Shower to Shower talc body powder. Any powder with talc on the ingredient line.</i>	Talc, printed right on the label. Asbestos, printed nowhere, because it is not an added ingredient. It is a contaminant that comes out of the same ground as the talc, and no law makes anyone list a contaminant. In 2019 the FDA found asbestos in a bottle of Johnson's Baby Powder bought off a store shelf, and Johnson and Johnson pulled 33,000 bottles. The company went to cornstarch in the United States and Canada in 2020 and worldwide in 2023, and talc is still on the ingredient line of body powders and pressed makeup powders sold here.	Asbestos is a known human carcinogen. The World Health Organization's cancer agency and the US National Toxicology Program both put it in that class, and neither one names a level that is safe to breathe. In July 2024 that same WHO agency rated talc itself probably carcinogenic to humans, its second highest grade, on evidence of ovarian cancer in women who used powder on their genitals. Tens of thousands of women are suing Johnson and Johnson over ovarian cancer they say the powder caused. The company denies it.	Stop dusting her. Pat her dry with a cloth and let the air do the rest, and buy her skincare from our own brand.
Diaper cream <i>Desitin Maximum Strength Original Paste</i>	Talc, listed by name as an inactive ingredient. Johnson and Johnson pulled talc out of baby powder worldwide in 2023, and on the FDA drug label filed in November 2024 it is still in Desitin Maximum Strength, the same company's diaper cream.	Ovarian cancer. Same mineral, same part of the body, rubbed on and left there under a diaper for hours.	Look at the tube in your bag, some now read corn starch. Then move her whole changing table to our own brand.
Baby shampoo, baby wash and bubble bath	1,4-dioxane. It is not on the label and it never will be, because it is not an ingredient. It is a contaminant created by the process that turns harsh detergent gentle, so it rides in on the things that are listed: sodium laureth sulfate, anything starting with PEG, polysorbate, anything ending in eth. If those words are on her bottle, you have no way to know how much of it is in there.	The Environmental Protection Agency classifies 1,4-dioxane as likely to be carcinogenic to humans. The National Toxicology Program lists it as reasonably anticipated to be a human carcinogen. New York made it illegal to sell a personal care product in that state with more than one part per million of it. There is no federal limit, and you cannot rinse off what you cannot read.	You cannot read a contaminant off a label, so wash her with our own brand.

THE PRODUCT	WHAT IS REALLY IN IT	WHAT IT DOES TO YOU	THE SWAP
Baby wash, baby shampoo and wipe solution <i>Johnson's Baby Shampoo, Aveeno Baby wash, Huggies wipes</i>	1,4-dioxane, and you will never find that word on a bottle of baby wash, because it is created during manufacturing instead of added as an ingredient and the FDA does not make anyone print it. It rides in on the parts that are printed, the PEG-80 sorbitan laurate and PEG-150 distearate in Johnson's Baby Shampoo, the polysorbate 20 in Aveeno Baby, the butoxy PEG-4 in Huggies wipes.	Cancer. Liver tumors.	If the label says PEG, laureth, polysorbate or anything with -eth- in it, it goes in the trash and our own brand goes in the tub.
Baby wipes, and every other wipe in the house	Methylisothiazolinone, printed right on the pack wherever it is used. American wipe makers took it out of baby wipes on their own after babies were burned by it in 2014. No agency made them do it, there is still no United States rule against it in wipes, and it is still on the label of hand wipes, face wipes, surface wipes and washes sitting in the same aisle.	It causes severe allergic skin reaction. In 2014 pediatric dermatologists reported American children with raw, weeping, blistered rashes on the bottom and the face traced back to methylisothiazolinone in wipes, and some had been treated for months for eczema or infection before anyone found the cause. Europe banned it in leave-on products including wet wipes on February 12, 2017, after its own safety committee said it could not identify any concentration that was safe for causing allergy. Once a child is sensitized, she reacts to it for life.	A warm wet washcloth at the changing table, and our own brand for the pack you carry in the diaper bag.
Baby lotion and anything that smells nice <i>Johnson's Baby Lotion, Johnson's Baby Shampoo, Aveeno Baby (printed as parfum), Desitin Maximum Strength, scented wipes, scented baby laundry detergent</i>	Fragrance. That one word covers the whole mixture, and federal rule 21 CFR 701.3 lets the company keep every chemical inside it off the label, phthalates included.	Hormone disruption. Phthalates interfere with the hormones that build a boy's reproductive system, and in 2008 Pediatrics measured the urine of 163 babies and found the ones who had been lotioned, powdered and shampooed carried more of them, with the number climbing for every extra product.	If you can smell it on her, it is in her. Unscented, and our own brand.
Diaper cream and kids' lotion	Propylparaben and butylparaben, listed by name on the back. Europe wrote a rule in 2014 that forbids these two in anything put on the diaper area of a child under three, and the United States has no such rule, so they are legal in American diaper cream today.	Hormone disruption. They act like estrogen in a body that is still building its hormone system, and the reason the European regulators gave was that a baby that age cannot metabolize them yet and diaper rash skin is already broken open.	Read the back of the tube for anything ending in paraben, then put her on our own brand.

Want to know which of these are in YOUR home?

Take the free 3 minute Home Scan. It walks your house room by room and gives you your score, and it tells you the one thing worth changing first.

scan.ismyhometoxic.com/now

From me to you. I have kept a non-toxic home for 34 years and I did the first ten of it on my own, with nobody to ask. I am not asking you to throw everything out this week. Pick one row. Do that one. Then do the next one. You are not behind, you have just never been told the truth about any of this.

Shannon Nicole, Founder, Switch to America

I am a health and nutrition coach, not a doctor, and nothing here is medical advice. Where I give an opinion I say so and I put my name on it. Copyright Shannon Nicole, Switch to America 2026.